Mohammad still longed for a British alliance, despite suffering multiple rebuffs. He also pointed to the Sikh seizure of Peshawar as the reason why Dost Mohammad had been forced to look elsewhere for allies. Most of all, he emphasised the immediate danger represented by Vitkevitch, and stressed that the unresolved state of Peshawar 'while it hangs over, brings intrigues to our door, and if not checked may shortly bring enemies instead of messengers'. He concluded that 'much more vigorous proceedings than the Government might wish or contemplate are necessary to counteract Russian and Persian intrigue in this quarter, than have been hitherto exhibited. It is indubitably true that we have an old and faithful ally in Maharaja Ranjit Singh but such an alliance will not keep these powers at a distance, or secure to us what is the end of all alliances, peace and prosperity in our country and on our frontiers.'[91]

Burnes did still have one trump card: Dost Mohammad had made it very clear that he would have preferred an alliance with Britain to one with Russia, and had gone out of his way to demonstrate this. Vitkevitch was being kept virtually under house arrest in the haveli of Dost Mohammad's Minister, Mirza Sami Khan, a much less grand lodging than that given to Burnes, and had still not yet been received by Dost Mohammad; all communication between the two still took place through the Minister. Vitkevitch was also kept under constant surveillance, and wrote to Simonitch that Dost Mohammad was behaving 'very coldly to me'. As Burnes wrote to a confidant,

> The Amir came over to me sharp, and offered to do as I liked – kick him [Vitkevitch] out or anything. I said not to do any such thing, but to give me the letters the agent has brought, all of which he surrendered sharp. I sent an express at once to my Lord Auckland with a confidential letter to the Governor General himself bidding him to look at what his predecessors had brought upon him, and telling him that after this, I know not what might happen, and it was now a neck and neck course between the Russian and us.[92]

The astonishingly undiplomatic orders that Burnes eventually received from Lord Auckland in answer to his repeated pleas were written on 21 January and arrived in Kabul exactly a month later. At one stroke Auckland undid all of Burnes's work and hopes. In the covering letter, Macnaghten dismissed his anxieties, explaining that he did not believe that Herat was in any real danger from either Persia or Russia, and that, bafflingly, 'His Lordship attaches little immediate importance to the mission of the Russian